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"Hi" Is All You Need

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Abstract

In two waves of a Vietnamese TikTok trend, couples posted the first messages they ever sent each other. We scanned 53,333 public posts and found 1,419 from the trend, about 58% of an estimated 2,400, then labelled who texted first. The man did in 71% of couples where the evidence allows a call (727 of 1,028; 95% interval 68 to 73). The man is also the older one 79% of the time, and still goes first in 64% of couples where the woman is older. Women send 36% of first messages during office hours and 16% before 09:00. Men declare their intent more than twice as often, while women more often find an excuse. Every couple in the sample got together, so this study says who started it and nothing about whose approach works.

Keywords: talking stage, thả thính, first-mover disadvantage, pronoun-based age inference, survivorship bias, Reviewer 2

1 Introduction

Most couples keep an official account of who texted first. It tends to change depending on who is telling it and whether the other person is in the room. Mothers raise the matter at family meals [1], yet the field has no reference dataset.

Earlier work studied first contact before anyone involved had anything to lose. On a US dating site, women were 4 times less likely than men to send messages, and the women who did write connected with more desirable partners than those who waited [2]. Across four large US cities, men and women alike pursued partners about 25% more desirable than themselves [3]. Field experiments have gone further and sent confederates to approach strangers directly [4], a design our ethics board, which is one mother, declined to reproduce.

Our source is a public TikTok trend from Vietnam. In September 2026, couples began posting photo carousels of how they first started talking, usually with screenshots of the messages themselves. Two cover lines dominate the trend: "Ủa hồi đó anh với em nhắn gì mà giờ thành đôi vậy" (mostly September) and "Khi bạn chỉ định nhắn tin thả thính cho vui mà mọi chuyện lại đi quá xa" (from late October). These posts offer something reviewers often request and rarely get. The outcome is known, because the couple is together and has decided to tell everyone.

This paper makes the following contributions:

1. A dataset of 1,419 trend posts drawn from 53,333 scanned, labelled for who sent the first message (Section 2).
2. The Anh Conjecture, and a test of whether it survives the woman being older (Sections 3.2 and 3.3).
3. A time zone analysis of first messages, broken down by sender (Section 3.4).
4. TIB-10, a taxonomy of ten opening moves grouped by how much the sender is willing to admit (Section 3.6).

2 Data and Methods

2.1 Collection

We ran a logged-in, read-only browser for about 20 hours, walking the trend's sound pages and running exact-phrase searches. The crawl scanned 53,333 public posts and found 1,419 trend posts with 48.1 million plays between them.

TikTok stops serving a sound after about 3,000 posts, so completeness is out of reach. The overlap between sound lists and search lists gives a capture-recapture estimate of the total, using Chapman's estimator:

$$\hat{N} = \frac{(n_1 + 1)(n_2 + 1)}{m + 1} - 1 \approx 2{,}400 \tag{1}$$

Here n_1 and n_2 are the sizes of the two lists and m is their overlap. We hold about 58% of that total. Both methods favor the same popular posts, so the real total is probably higher.

2.2 Labelling

Apple's Vision OCR read the screenshots, and language-model agents labelled each post. A blind second pass agreed with the first on 44 of 45 first movers. Codex, reading 60 name-scrubbed chats independently, matched on who is older in 40 of 40 cases where both answered and on the first mover in 12 of 13. Against 10 real screenshots, first sender, true start and time matched in all 10.

Definition 1 (Talking stage)**.** The interval that begins with the first message and ends when one party asks what this is. We do not measure its end.

Definition 2 (Evidence tiers)**.** Proof: the true start of the chat is visible, or the couple states who went first. Screen: Proof plus posts where we use the earliest message shown. Guess: Screen plus posts where the sender's gender comes from assuming who posted, using chat text or display name where possible and otherwise assuming a woman.

Unless noted, we report all three tiers together. Relative age comes from how the couple address each other (*anh/em*, *chị/em*). Stated ages are too rare to use, and we do not estimate ages from faces.

3 Results

3.1 Who texted first

The man sent the first message in 727 of 1,028 couples (71%, Wilson 95% interval [5] 68 to 73; see Figure 1). Stricter evidence barely moves it: 72% of 585 couples with Proof only, and 70% of 816 with Proof + Screen. In the US dating data the ratio was 4 to 1 [2], and here it is about 2.4 to 1. The two populations differ in country, platform and outcome, so the comparison means little, and we report it anyway.



Figure 1: The man texted first in 71% of couples: 727 couples, against 301 where the woman did.

3.2 The Anh Conjecture

Observation 1 (The Anh Conjecture)**.** *In couples whose age order can be read, the man is older in 483 of 609 cases (79%). See Figure 2.*

Proof sketch. In 483 couples, someone said *anh* and meant it.

The direction agrees with a study of mate preferences across 37 samples [6], which needed questionnaires in 33 countries where we needed the word *anh*. Our estimate probably runs high, since couples can use *anh/em* at the same age.

3.3 When the woman is older

Proposition 1. *When the woman is older, the man still sends the first message in 63 of 99 couples (64%). When the man is older, the figure is 336 of 476 (71%). See Figure 3.*

Older women may start things a little more often. With Proof only, the gap narrows to 69% against 72%, on 55 older-

woman couples, so we report it as a hint. Hints are a recognized opening strategy (Section 3.6).

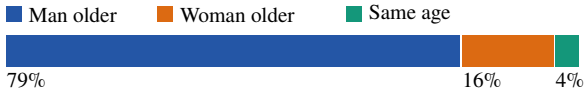


Figure 2: The man is the older one 79% of the time. Age order read from how each couple addresses each other (609 couples).

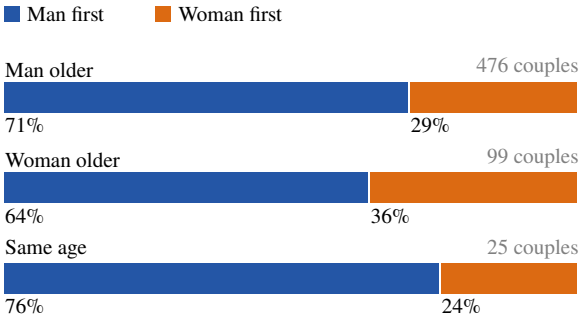


Figure 3: Even when the woman is older, the man usually still goes first. Share of first messages by who is older.

3.4 Time zones

We split the day into three time zones by the hour of the first message (Figure 4). In the Nocturnal Zone, from midnight to 09:00, women sent 19 of 120 first messages (16%). In the Administrative Zone, from 09:00 to 18:00, they sent 91 of 253 (36%). The Evening Zone sits between them at 27%. The gap between the first two has $z = 4.0$ and survives restricting to Proof (14% against 37%).

Volume peaks between 21:00 and midnight, which holds 31% of all first messages in 3 of the 24 hours. No first message in the sample was sent between 04:00 and 04:59.

Reviewer 2 asked for a mechanism. We propose that a message sent during office hours can be defended as being about work. We have no evidence for this.

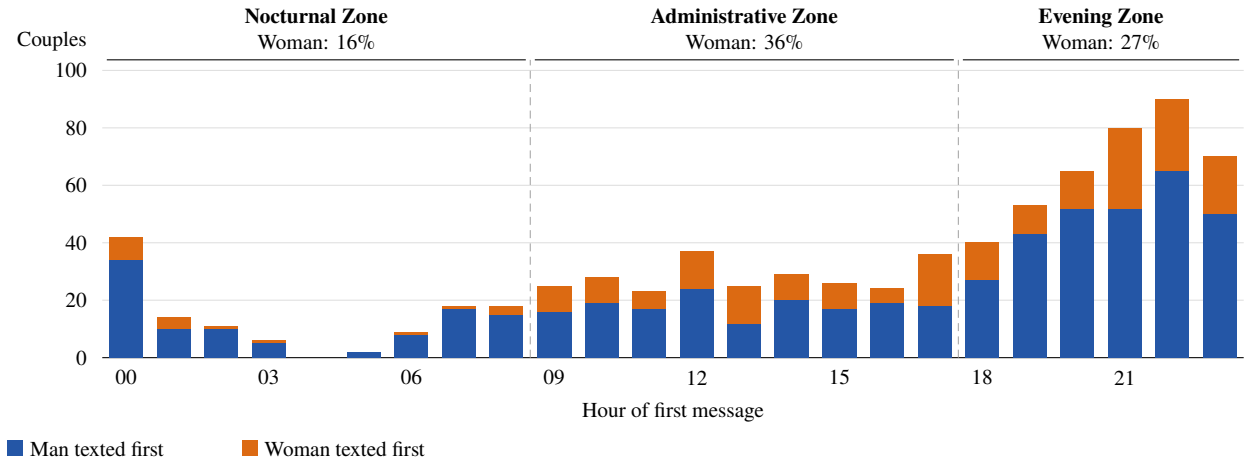


Figure 4: First messages by hour of the day, Vietnam time. Each bar counts the couples whose first message was sent in that hour, split by who sent it. The percentage above each zone is the woman's share of first messages in that zone.

3.5 How it opened, and where

Messenger carries 652 of the 796 conversations with an identifiable platform (82%). Zalo, home of the family group chat, has 75. The most common opening is a reply to a story (192 posts): someone broadcasts to all their friends and one friend takes it personally. Plain greetings come second at 188 (Figure 5). The opening type is our weakest label, matching our check on 22 of 29 posts.

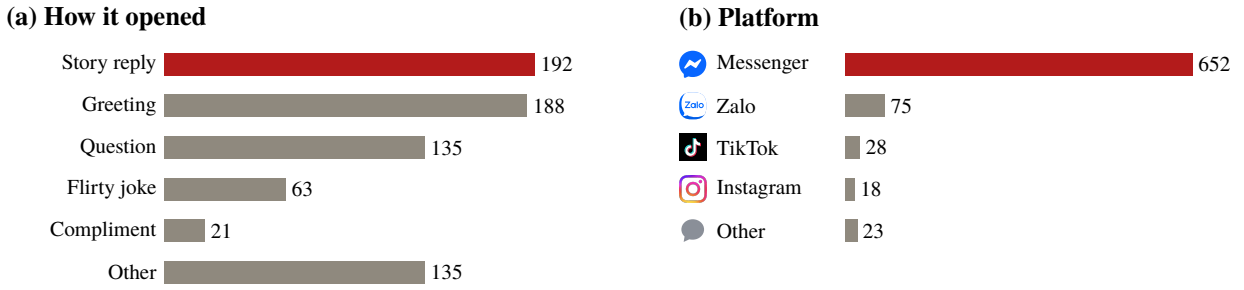


Figure 5: (a) How the conversation opened. (b) The platform it happened on.

3.6 TIB-10: the Taxonomy of Initiation Behaviours

We tagged 960 openers into ten styles without telling the tagger who sent each one. A blind re-tag of 100 agreed on 90. Figure 6 groups the styles into three families according to how much the sender admits to wanting something.

Proposition 2 (Asymmetric Declaration)**.** *Men open with declared intent in 108 of 682 openers (16%). Women do so in 19 of 278 (7%).*

Women lean on excuses instead, at 16.2% against 9.2% for men. In couples where the man is older, the gap grows to 25.0% against 8.8%. Compliments split hardest, at 6.2% of male openers and 0.7% of female ones. Across all 960 openers, the word *xinh* appears in 23 from men and none from women. Vietnamese has a phrase for calling a man handsome, *đẹp trai*, and nobody used it.

We formed the families after seeing the tags. With ten styles compared, gaps under about 5 points may be chance.

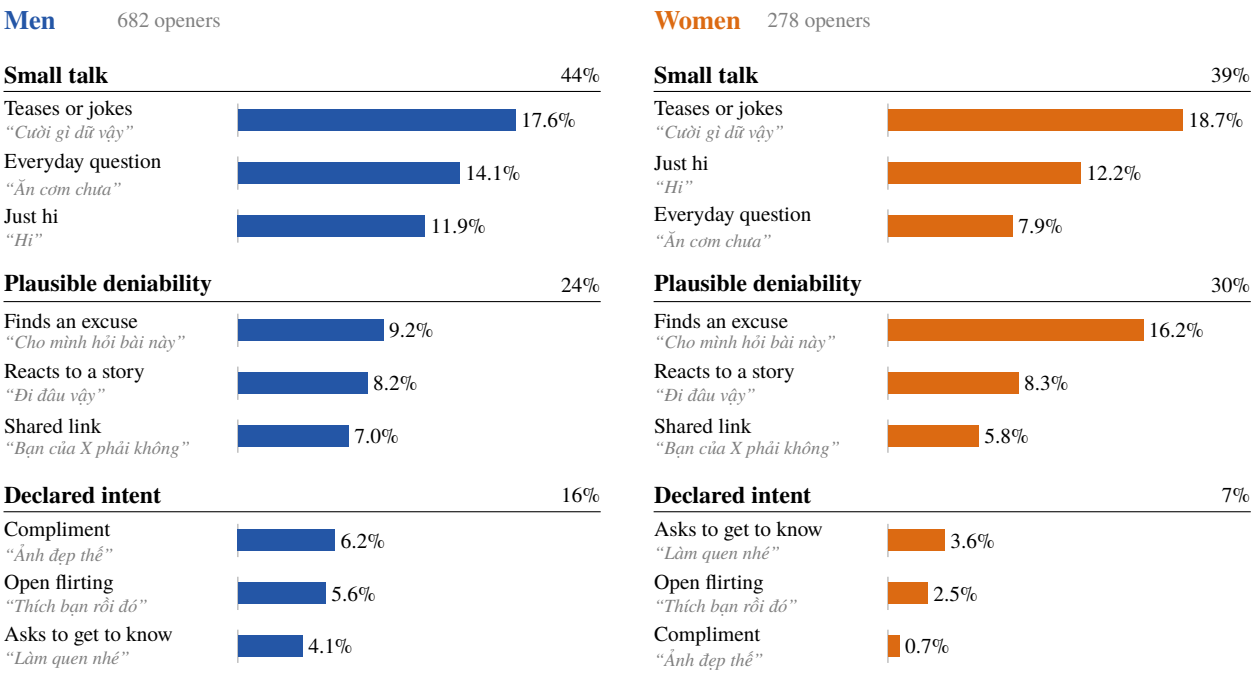


Figure 6: TIB-10. Share of men's and of women's openers in each style, on the same scale in both columns and sorted within each. In Declared intent the sender admits to wanting something, in Plausible deniability the sender has a reason to be there, and in Small talk nothing has been admitted yet. Examples are invented in the same style. The remaining openers fall under Other and are not shown. 682 openers from men and 278 from women.

4 Threats to Validity

Survivorship is total. The sample contains only talking stages that worked out and got posted, so we cannot estimate anyone's success rate, and every unanswered "hi" is missing. We ask readers to remember this before trying anything.

Posters are not a random draw. Where gender is clear from the post, 91% are women (691 of 758), and a man doing the chasing may simply be the better story to post. Couples also choose which screenshots to show, and 370 posts show only photos or a caption. The 212 Guess couples (21% of the total) rest on an assumption about who posted. Without them the man's share is 70%.

We ran about 60 comparisons for Table 1, so some of its small-count results will be flukes.

5 Conclusion

Men sent about 71% of first messages in this sample, and the man still went first in most couples where the woman is older. Women's share of first messages peaks in office hours, and their openers rely more on excuses. The most repeated exact opener in the data is "hi", used by 7 couples. We do not recommend it. We can only report that it failed to prevent 7 relationships. The title follows a convention in machine learning [7] and is not a finding.

Table 1: Findings no reviewer requested

Finding	**Value**
Lexical markers (men / women)	
Openers containing "xinh"	23 / 0
Openers containing "đẹp"	21 / 1
Openers containing "chào"	6.6% / 3.2%
Openers containing "ơi"	4.0% / 9.0%
Median opener length	22 / 21 characters
Rude openers	4 / 6
All chats containing ":))"	24%
Founding excuses (openers)	
Homework	8
TikTok streak	7 (6 from women)
Borrowing phone credit	4
Asking for a bank number	4
Prior acquaintance (man went first)	
Classmates	23 of 30
Friends or mutual friends	64 of 85
Strangers online	79 of 112
Exes and old contacts	17 of 26
Coworkers	20 of 32
Introduced by family	5 of 9
Project timeline	
Earliest first message in the sample	2014
Busiest year for first messages	2025 (151 couples)
Married within 7 months of the first text	7 of 43
Longest first text to wedding	10 years
Publication bias	
Median likes, woman went first / man went first	92 / 65
Woman went first: caption-only claims / chat on screen	42% / 27%
Woman went first, male posters vs female posters	41% vs 28%
Same, Proof only: hypothesis rejected	28% vs 28%

Acknowledgment

Labels came from Claude sub-agents and one Codex run. No grant funded this work. The format is a parody: the counts are real, the preprint server is invented, and nobody has peer reviewed any of it.

Data Availability

Row-level data stay private. These couples posted for their friends and did not sign up to be a dataset, so this paper reports counts only, and the example openers in Figure 6 are made up.

References

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